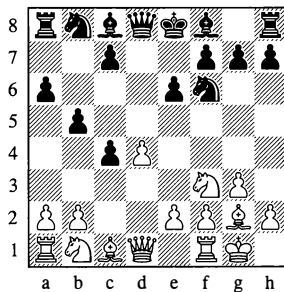


Chapter 8

Catalan 4...dxc4



5...a6 and 6...b5

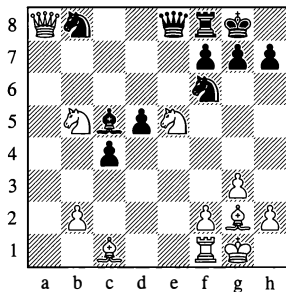
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 a6 6.0-0 b5

7.♘e5

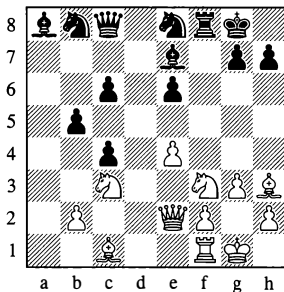
A) 7...c6	113
B) 7...♘d5 8.a4 ♙b7 9.e4 ♘f6 10.axb5 axb5 11.♖xa8 ♙xa8 12.♘c3 c6 13.d5	114
B1) 13...cxd5	115
B2) 13...♙d6	117
B3) 13...exd5	119
B4) 13...♙e7 14.dxe6 fxe6 15.♚e2 0-0 16.♙h3	120
B41) 16...♙h8	121
B42) 16...♚c8	123

B3) after 17...♚e8!



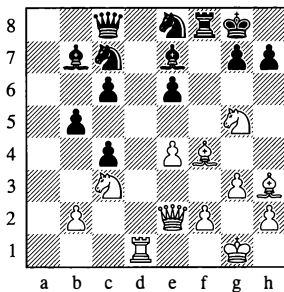
18.♚b7!N

B42) note to 17...♘a6



18.♙g5N

B42) after 20...♙b7



21.♚e3N

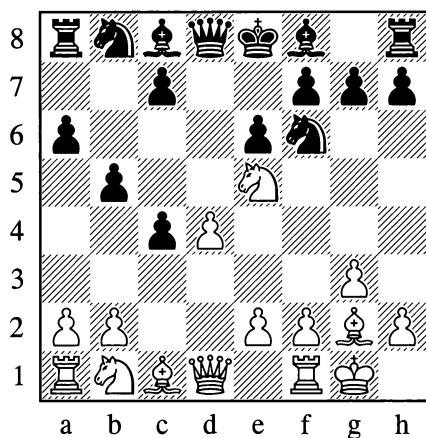
1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♟f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 a6 6.0–0

6.♟e5 is an important alternative for White in this position, but I am sticking with my preference from *GM 1*.

6...b5

This is the most direct way to hold on to the extra pawn and Black's second most important choice in this position.

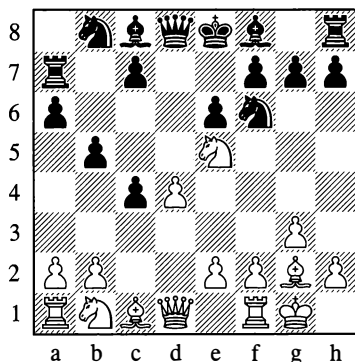
7.♟e5



This is the first branching position in this variation. Black's only playable alternative is A) 7...c6, while the main line is B) 7...♟d5.

7...♙a7?!

This is clearly inferior in view of:



8.a4!

Breaking up Black's pawn structure.

8...♙b7 9.axb5 ♙xg2 10.♙xg2 ♖d5† 11.♙g1
Though this is good, I prefer 11.e4!N ♖xb5
(Or 11...♖xe4† 12.f3 ♖b7 13.♖a4 ♟fd7
14.♟c3 ♙d6 15.♟xd7 ♟xd7 16.bxa6 ♖b3
17.♖xb3 cxb3 18.♟b5 ♙a8 19.♙d1+–.
Black is helpless against White's idea of
picking up the b3-pawn by means of ♙d1-
d3xb3.) 12.♟c3 ♖b3 13.♖e2 ♙b4 14.♙e3
♟bd7 15.♟xc4± White has a big positional
advantage.

11...♖xb5

Two games have reached this position, when
White should play the simple:

12.♟c3N ♖b3 13.♙a4

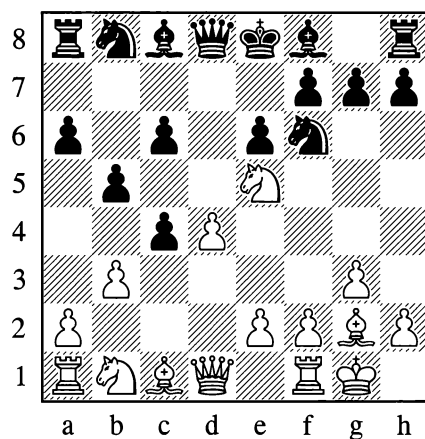
Regaining the c4-pawn and maintaining a
clear positional advantage.

A) 7...c6

White has a strong idea at his disposal:

8.b3

8.♟xc6 ♖b6 is another line, which we will
not go into at this point.



8...cxb3 9.♟xc6 ♖b6 10.♟a5! ♙a7 11.♟xb3 ♙d7

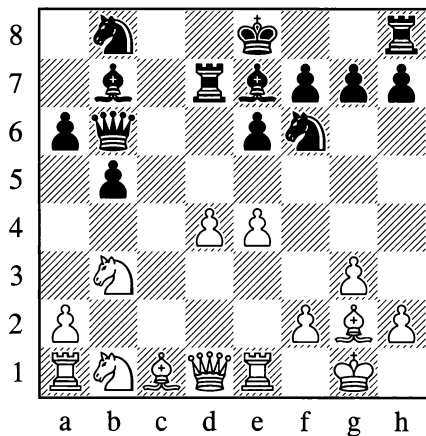
11...♙e7 does not change the character of the
game: 12.e4 0–0 13.♙e3 ♙d7 14.♟1d2 ♖d8

15.a4! bxa4 16.♞xa4± with definite positional pressure, Razuvaev – M. Gurevich, Riga 1985.

11...♙b7?! allows White to seize an early initiative with 12.d5!, creating the threat of 13.♙e3. After 12...♞c7 13.♙e3 ♞a8 14.dxe6 (my engine gives the amazing 14.♘c3!, when the knight is untouchable in view of 14...♞xc3 15.♞c1 ♞e5 16.dxe6! and White is winning) 14...fxe6 15.♙xb7 ♞xb7 16.♘d4± White was clearly better in Lingnau – Thesing, Germany 1992.

12.e4 ♙b7 13.♞c1 ♙e7

Most probably Black should have tried the more active 13...♙b4, but even then after 14.♙d2 ♙xd2 15.♘1xd2 0–0 16.a4± White has clear targets on the queenside.



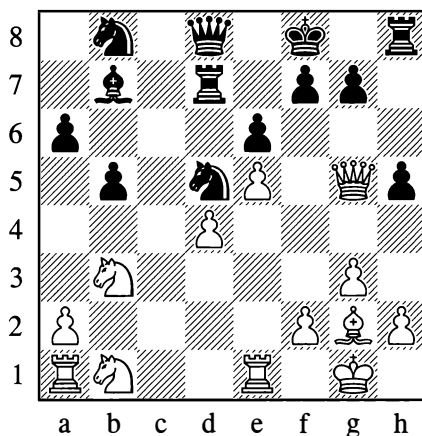
14.e5! ♘d5 15.♞g4

As always, this queen sortie is unpleasant for Black. We will follow his most recent attempt to hold the position:

15...♞f8

15...g6 16.♙h6 ♘b4 17.♙xb7 ♞xb7 18.♞e2 (defending against ...♘c2) 18...♘8c6 19.♘c3± Black's king will be stuck in the centre for a long time and his prospects are grim, Krasenkow – Kohlweyer, Ostend 1990.

16.♙g5 h5 17.♞h4 ♙xg5 18.♞xg5 ♞d8



19.♞xd8†

White maintains the pressure in the arising endgame, though I would prefer to keep the queens on by means of 19.♞d2N.

19...♞xd8 20.♞c1 ♙e7 21.♘c3

White maintains a nagging edge, Querci – De Carlos Arregui, email 2011.

B) 7...♘d5

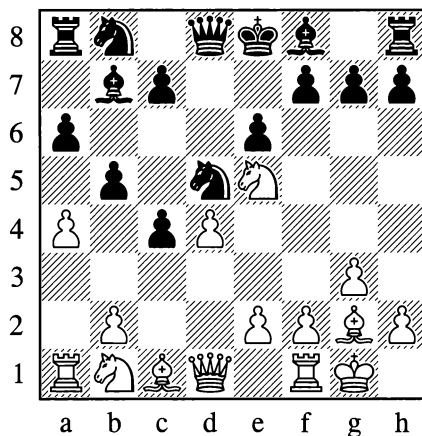
This is by far Black's most popular reply.

8.a4

Definitely the most ambitious continuation. White's main alternatives are 8.♘c3 and 8.e4.

8...♙b7

8...c6 9.axb5 cxb5 10.b3 cxb3 11.♞xb3 ♙b7 transposes to Chapter 9. See page 128 for the continuation, beginning with 12.e4.



9.e4

The most popular move for White has been 9.b3, but I believe Black has a great positional piece sacrifice at his disposal: 9...c3! 10.axb5 axb5 11.♖xa8 ♙xa8 12.e4 b4!! 13.exd5 ♙xd5 With unclear play.

9.axb5 axb5 10.♖xa8 ♙xa8 11.e4 ♘f6 is just another move order that transposes to our main line.

9...♘f6

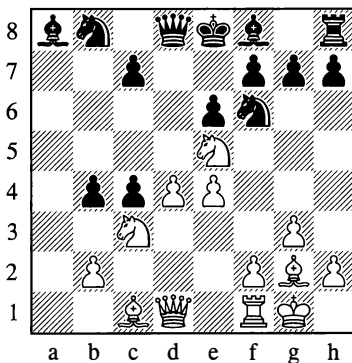
This is the black knight's only retreat according to theory. It is very important for Black to control the h5-square, otherwise the queen's sortie to h5 will pose Black definite problems.

I also checked another knight move: 9...♘b4?!N 10.axb5 axb5 11.♖xa8 ♙xa8 12.♞h5! g6 (12...♞e7 13.♙g5 g6 14.♞h4 looks even worse for Black) 13.♘xg6! This is the point behind White's 12th move. 13...fxg6 14.♞e5 ♘8c6 15.♞xh8 ♞xd4 16.♞xh7 White has a technically winning position.

10.axb5 axb5 11.♖xa8 ♙xa8 12.♘c3 c6

12...b4!:

This dubious move has rarely been played, and for good reason:



13.♞a4! ♘bd7 14.♘b5 ♙xe4

14...♙b7 does not change anything: 15.♞a7

♞b8 16.♞xb8! ♘xb8 17.♘xc7! ♔e7 18.d5± with a large advantage.

15.♙xe4 ♘xe4 16.♘c6 ♘b6

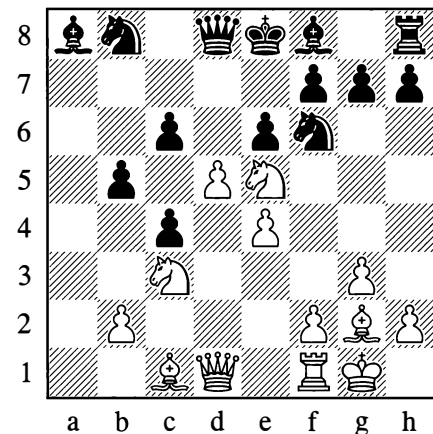
I also examined the following funny line: 16...♞c8 17.♞a8! ♘b6 18.♘xc7! ♔d7 19.♘e5! ♔xc7 (19...♔e7 20.♞a7+- is also hopeless for Black) 20.♞c6! ♔d8 (20...♔b8 allows mate in four after 21.♞xb6!) 21.♞xb6! ♔e8 22.♞b5+- White wins.

17.♞a7

White was winning in Cirino – Wingender, email 2001.

13.d5

I have no doubt that this central thrust is the most challenging move. 13.♙g5 is the main alternative, but it does not look effective to me.



Finally we have reached the main branching position of this line. Black has a choice of four different moves: B1) 13...cxd5, B2) 13...♙d6, B3) 13...exd5 and B4) 13...♙e7.

B1) 13...cxd5 14.exd5

White has no advantage after 14.♘xb5 ♞a5!.

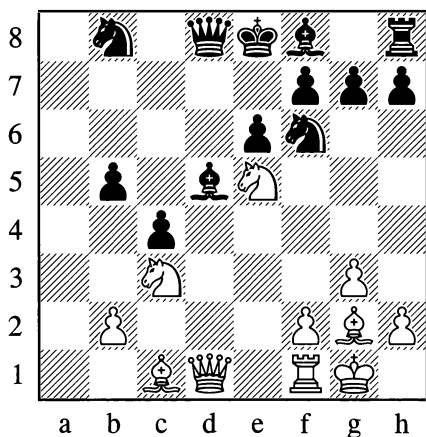
14...♙xd5

Naturally Black has other possible recaptures:

14...exd5 15.♘xb5 ♞a5? (The best move is

15...♙c5!, as examined in variation B3, arising from the 13...exd5 move order.) This position has occurred three times, but for some reason White has never played the simple 16.♞e2!N when Black's position is hopeless. For instance, 16...♙e7 (16...♞xb5 loses to 17.♟g6† ♜d7 18.♟xh8) 17.♟d6† ♙xd6 18.♟xc4† wins the black queen.

14...♟xd5 15.♞h5 (15.♟xb5!? also comes into consideration.) 15...g6 (15...♞f6 16.♙xd5 ♙xd5 17.♟xd5 exd5± transposes to the position from the game Kohlweyer – Nisipeanu, Germany 1997, which is examined in the note to Black's 15th move in the main line below.) 16.♟xg6! We will see this blow again in the main line. 16...fxg6 17.♞e5 ♟xc3 18.♙xa8 ♟e2† 19.♞xe2 ♞f6 20.♙d2± White's initiative looks very powerful.



15.♙xd5!

White should get a clear advantage by playing in this way. Less clear is 15.♟xd5.

15...exd5

15...♟xd5

This loses control over the h5-square, after which the standard queen lift is very effective.

16.♞h5! g6

After 16...♞f6 17.♟xd5 exd5 18.♞e1 ♙e7

(18...♙b4? loses to 19.♟g4†) White could have decided the game with the smooth 19.♙g5!N (19.♟xc4? 0–0 led to an equal position in Kohlweyer – Nisipeanu, Germany 1997) 19...♞f5 (19...♞xg5 20.♞xf7† ♜d8 21.♞xd5† ♜c7 22.♞xb5+— doesn't help either) 20.♟g6! with a decisive advantage.

17.♟xg6!

As promised, this tactical blow returns.

17...fxg6 18.♞e5 ♟f6

18...♞f6 19.♞xb8† ♜f7 20.♞xb5 would leave White with an extra pawn, as the c4-pawn is falling next.

19.♞xe6† ♞e7

If 19...♙e7 then 20.♞d1 easily decides the game: 20...♟bd7 21.♟xb5+—

20.♞c8† ♞d8

The most tenacious defence. 20...♜f7 21.♞xb8 b4 22.♟b5± leads to an obvious advantage for White.

Now we have a logical sequence of moves:

21.♞e1† ♙e7 22.♞e6 ♞f8 23.♟xb5 ♞d7 24.♞xc4 ♞c6 25.♞b3 ♟a6 26.♙h6

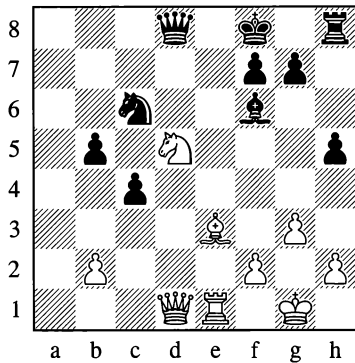
Black is in serious trouble, as was proven in Evans – Sindelar, email 2009.

16.♟g4!

This fine move opens the e-file for White's rook and allows him to use his lead in development.

16...♟e4

16...♙e7 17.♟xf6† ♙xf6 (17...gxf6 18.♟xd5 looks hopeless for Black) 18.♞e1† ♜f8 (18...♙e7 loses by force after 19.♟xd5 ♟c6 20.♙g5 f6 21.♙xf6! gxf6 22.♞h5† ♜f8 23.♞e6!+—) 19.♟xd5 and White has a decisive initiative for the pawn. 19...♟c6 20.♙e3 h5 (20...♙e7 21.♞h5 also leads to a large advantage for White). In *GM I* I stated that 21.♙c5† would be decisive here, and this was shown to be the case in the following game:



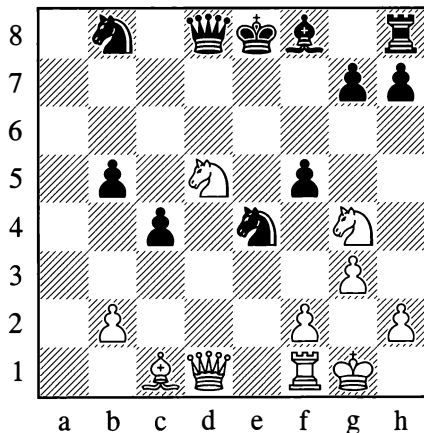
21. ♖c5† ♜g8 22. ♕e7! A beautiful solution.
22... ♞c8 23. ♕xf6 gxf6 24. ♜xf6† ♜g7
25. ♜xh5† White had a winning position in
Eljanov – I. Novikov, Israel 2011.

17. ♜xd5 f5

Black's most recent attempt to hold the position.

17... ♕e7 loses to 18. ♞d4.

17... ♕c5 18. b4!! Brilliantly played: this advance allows the white queen to enter the game with great effect. 18... cxb3 19. ♞d3 f5 (19... ♜d6 loses to 20. ♞c3, attacking both the bishop on c5 and the g7-pawn) 20. ♞xb5† ♜d7 21. ♜e5 White's advantage proved to be decisive in Ghafari – Skulteti, email 2002.



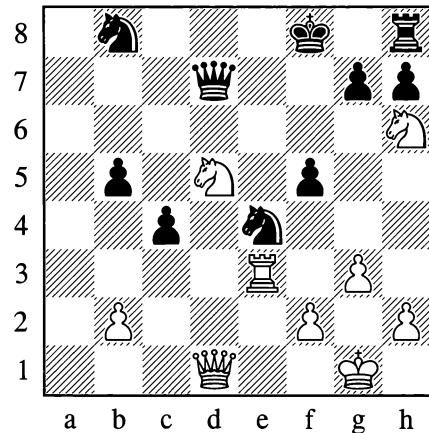
18. ♜h6!

An amusing yet powerful response.

18... ♞d7 19. ♞e1 ♕c5 20. ♕e3 ♕xe3 21. ♞xe3

There is no saving Black now.

21... ♜f8



22. ♞f3! gxf6 23. ♞d4 ♜g8 24. ♞xf5

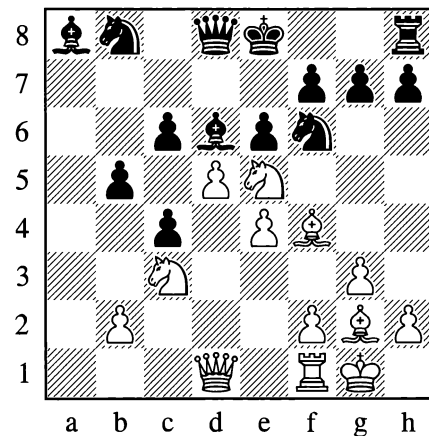
White delivered checkmate shortly afterwards in Zawadski – Kruk, corr. 2012.

B2) 13... ♕d6

This looks fairly natural, but with his next move White uses the vulnerable position of Black's bishop on d6 to grab the initiative.

14. ♕f4

Less convincing is 14. ♜g4 ♕e7!.

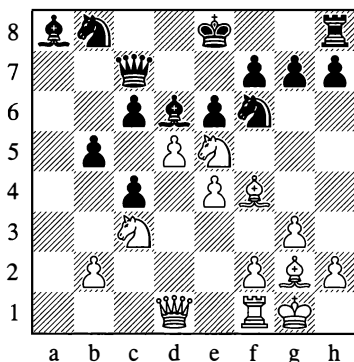


14...♙xe5

Black has a wide choice of moves, but nothing really helps.

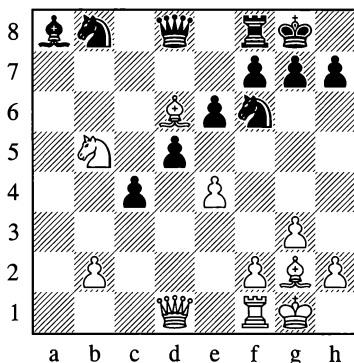
Certainly 14...g5? does not work: 15.dxe6 fxe6 16.♘xc6!+–

14...♞c7 is rather critical:



15.♘xf7! ♔xf7 16.dxe6† ♔e7 (The e6-pawn is untouchable in view of 16...♙xe6 17.♙h3† ♔e7 18.e5! ♙xe5 19.♙xe5 ♞xe5 20.♞e1 and White wins.) 17.♙xd6† ♞xd6 18.♞a1! (the point of White's sacrifice) 18...♙b7 19.♞a7 ♞c7 20.e5! (I recommended 20.♞c5 in *GM 1*, but this is much more convincing.) 20...♘e8 21.♞d1 ♙c8 22.♞c5† ♔xe6 23.♘e4 ♞e7 24.♘d6 White crashes through.

After 14...cxd5 15.♘xb5 ♙xe5 16.♙xe5 0–0 Black has almost unravelled his position, but 17.♙d6 wins the exchange and it doesn't seem as if Black has sufficient compensation. For example:



17...♘xe4 (or 17...♞b6 18.♙xf8 ♞xb5 19.♙e7± Feldmann – Rolle, email 2009) 18.♙xf8 ♞xf8 19.♙xe4 dxe4 20.♞a4! ♙c6 21.♞xc4 White's material advantage should decide the game, as in Hollands – Laczay, email 2010.

14...exd5 15.exd5 cxd5

Black has no time for 15...0–0, as after 16.♘xc6 ♘xc6 17.dxc6 ♙xf4 18.♞xd8 ♞xd8 19.gxf4 White's passed pawn easily decides the issue.

16.♞a1 ♙xe5

16...d4 is met by 17.♞xa8 ♙xe5 18.♙xe5 dxc3 19.♞a3!, which wins on the spot.

16...♙b7 is nicely refuted by 17.♞a7 ♞c8 18.♘d7!!, with two lines to consider:

a) 18...♙xf4 19.♞e1† ♘e4 (19...♙xd7 obviously loses to 20.♙h3†) 20.♘e4 dxe4 21.♙xe4 ♙xe4 22.♞xe4† ♔d8 23.♘xb8 ♞xb8 24.♞d4†! ♔e8 25.♞d7† ♔f8 26.♙xf4 ♞e8 27.♞d2 and White will at least pick up both of Black's queenside pawns.

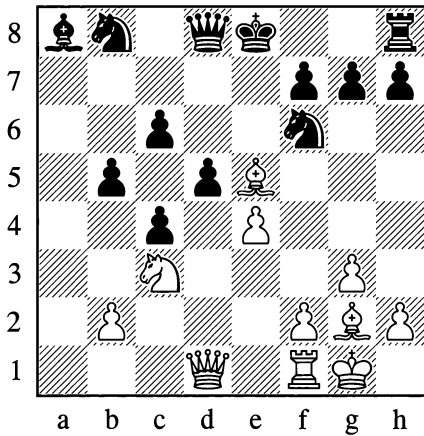
b) 18...♞xd7 19.♙xd6 ♞xd6 20.♞e1† ♔f8 (20...♘e4 21.♞xb7 0–0 22.♘d5 ♘f6 23.♞xb5 and the c4-pawn will soon drop) 21.♘b5 ♞d8 22.♞xb7 g6 23.♘c7 ♘bd7 24.♙xd5 ♔g7 25.♙xc4 ♞b8 26.♞xb8 ♞xb8 27.♘b5 White is a healthy pawn up.

17.♙xe5

We have reached the position from our main line with 14...♙e5.

15.♙xe5 exd5N

15...0–0 leads to a clear advantage for White after: 16.dxe6 fxe6 (there is no doubt the endgame after 16...♞xd1 17.exf7† ♔xf7 18.♞xd1 is very difficult for Black, due to his poorly placed minor pieces on the queenside) 17.♙d6 ♞e8 18.e5 ♘d5 19.♘e4± White has every chance of deciding the game with a direct attack, Tolstikh – Paramonov, St Petersburg 2002.

**16.exd5 cxd5**

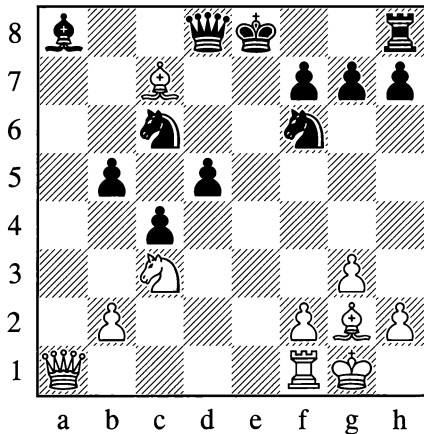
Probably more stubborn is 16...0-0, but even here after 17.♖a1 ♜bd7 18.♙d6 White is clearly better.

17.♖a1

By transposition we have reached a position from a game by Ulibin, which continued:

17...♜c6 18.♙c7!

Only this elegant tactical blow allows White to develop a dangerous initiative.

**18...♙xc7**

18...♙c8 19.♞e1+ ♜f8 20.♙d6+ ♜g8 21.♜xd5 is strategically lost for Black.

19.♙xa8+ ♜d8

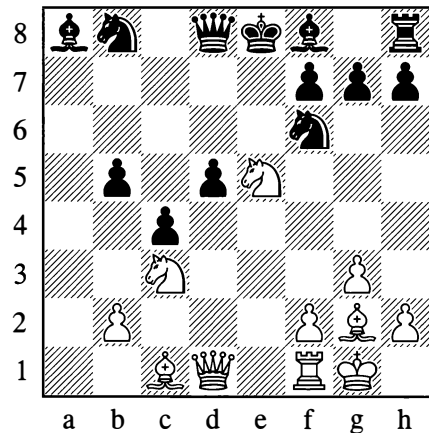
19...♜b8 20.♞e1+ ♜d8 21.♜xd5 wins for White as well.

20.♞e1+ ♜f8 21.♙a3+ ♜g8 22.♜xd5+-

White won in a few moves in Ulibin – Antunes, Cuba 1991.

B3) 13...exd5 14.exd5 cxd5

14...♜xd5? would be a serious mistake, as it allows 15.♙h5 ♙f6 16.♜xc6!+- and Black's position collapses.

**15.♜xb5 ♙c5!**

This line looks to be the only playable alternative to the main variation with 13...♙e7.

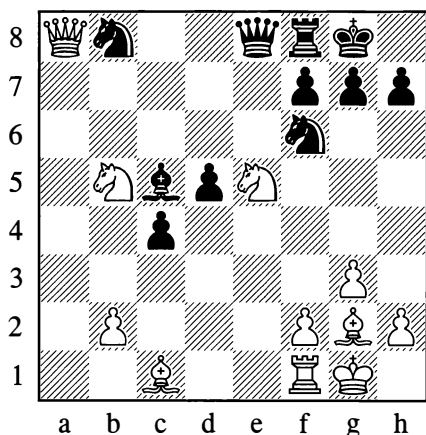
15...♙a5? was discussed on page 115, in the note to Black's 14th move of variation B1.

16.♙a4

Black has no reason for concern after 16.♜xc4 0-0 17.♙e3 ♜bd7=.

16...0-0 17.♙xa8 ♙e8!

This double attack is the point behind Black's 15th move. There have been only two games where this position arose, and in both of them Black was perfectly okay from a theoretical point of view. For this reason I would like to recommend the following improvement:



18.♖b7?!!N

White has tried 18.♖c3 ♖xe5 19.♗f4 and now instead of 19...♗h5?! as in V. Mikhalevski – Naiditsch, Heviz 2008, Black should have played 19...♗e6N 20.♖xd5 ♖bd7 21.♖xf6† ♖xf6 22.♗a5 ♗d4 23.♗e1 ♗b6= when I believe the bishop pair is not so relevant, as Black will be able to swap the queenside pawns.

18.♗xd5 ♗xb5 19.♗xc4 ♗xf2† 20.♗xf2 ♗xe5 was Plauth Herr – Daw, corr. 1996. White is marginally better, but the slightly exposed position of his king allows Black sufficient counterplay.

18...♗xe5 19.♗f4 ♗e7

The piece sacrifice hardly works: 19...♗xb2?! 20.♗xb8 ♖g4 (or 20...d4 21.♗e5 ♖g4 22.♗c6 and White should be winning) 21.♗d6 ♗xd6 22.♖xd6 ♗xb7 23.♖xb7 d4. Now best is 24.♖a5 c3 25.♗e4 and White should convert his material advantage.

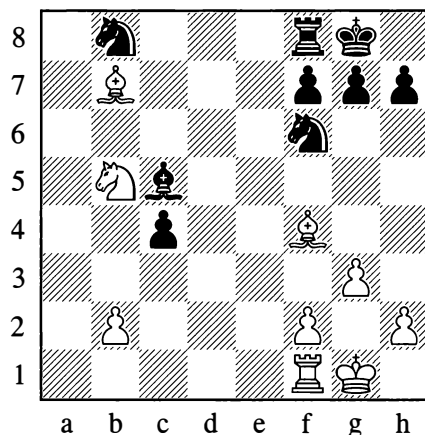
19...♗e8 20.♖c7 ♗a4 21.♖xd5 ♖bd7 22.♖c3 ♗a5 23.♗c6 (White should watch out for tactics, for example the most natural 23.♗d1 runs into 23...g5!) 23...♗b6 24.♖a4 ♗xb7 25.♗xb7± and Black is doomed to long-term suffering.

20.♗xd5 ♗xb7

After 20...♖xd5 21.♗xd5 Black loses the c4-pawn.

21.♗xb7

Black cannot swap the queenside pawns, so White keeps definite pressure with his pair of bishops.



21...♖bd7 22.♗d1 h6 23.♗f1 ♖b6 24.♖c3 ♗e8 25.♗f3±

Black is still far from equality, as White has the advantage of the two bishops and the c4-pawn could become a target in some endgames.

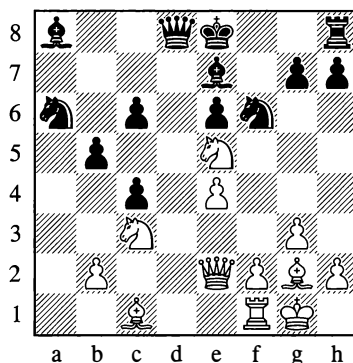
B4) 13...♗e7

By far the main continuation and the move you are most likely to face in practice.

14.dxe6 fxe6 15.♗e2 0–0

15...♖a6

Here I believe White has an opportunity to react energetically:



16.♞d1!

The novelty which I recommended in *GM 1* has now been successfully employed.

After 16.♙e3 Black has only tried 16...♜c5?! 17.♞d1 ♞c7 18.♜xc4! e5 (It was better to accept the sacrifice with 18...bxc4 19.♞xc4 ♜cd7, though after 20.♞xe6 ♞e5 21.♞b3♞ White has two pawns and a powerful initiative for the piece.) 19.b4 ♜cd7 20.♞a2 ♙b7 21.♜a5± and White had a great positional advantage with equal material, J. Horvath – Hoelzl, Budapest 1994.

However, Black can improve with the simple 16...0–0 17.♙h3 ♞c8! and get a good version of our main line.

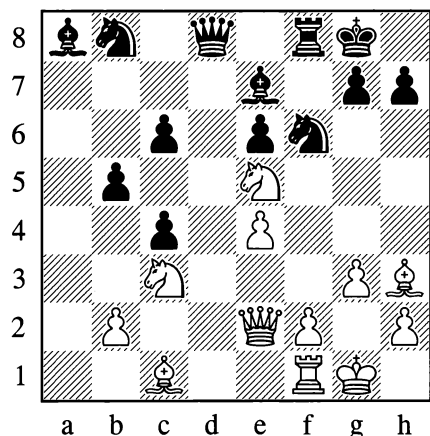
16...♞b6

16...♞c8 17.g4! To tell the truth, I have never come across this idea in this variation before, but it appears to be very strong in this case. For example: 17...0–0 18.g5 ♜e8 19.♜d7 ♞f7 20.g6! hxg6 21.♜e5 Black has to give up the exchange.

17.♙h3 ♜c5 18.♙e3 ♞b8 19.f4 ♞c8 20.♜f1 ♜d3 21.♜xd3 cxd3 22.♞xd3

White regained his pawn with a clear positional advantage in Curator – Gbsalvio, Internet 2010.

16.♙h3



At this late stage in the chapter, we still

have two options to look at. The alternative to protecting the e6-pawn is rather surprisingly to give it up with **B41)** 16...♜h8. As Black is a pawn up, he should consider this, but it appears to make too much of a monster out of White's e-pawn. Therefore **B42)** 16...♞c8 continues to be the main line.

16...♞e8 17.♙xe6† ♜h8 is a simple transposition to variation B41 below.

B41) 16...♜h8 17.♙xe6

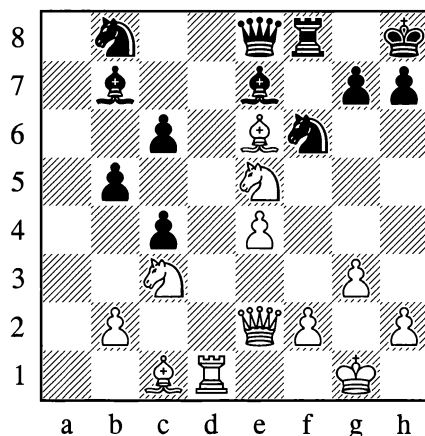
In a grandmaster game 17.♙e3 was tested. I believe Black should calmly defend his pawn with 17...♞c8 and not play 17...b4 18.♜b1± as in V. Mikhalevski – Nisipeanu, Heviz 2008.

17...♞e8 18.♞d1

Somehow I do not like 18.♙f5, which was played in Krasenkow, – Kaidanov, Gausdal 1991. For example, Black can try 18...♜bd7 19.♜xd7 ♜xd7, when he has a clear plan of penetrating with his knight to the d3-square.

18...♙b7

Another line to consider is 18...c5 19.♙f4 ♜c6 20.♜xc6 ♙xc6 when White has the strong: 21.♜d5!N (The solid and positional 21.f3, restricting the mobility of Black's minor pieces, might be a serious alternative.) 21...♜xd5 22.exd5 ♙b7 23.d6 The d-pawn should easily decide the game.



19. ♖e3

This is my new suggestion.

In *GM 11* I recommended:

19. ♖f4

Threatening to play 20. ♖f7† as Black's knight will be hanging at the end of the variation.

19... ♖a6 20. ♖d7 ♖xd7 21. ♖xd7 ♖f7 22. e5
22. ♖d6?! allows Black to create counterplay:
22... ♖c5 23. e5 ♖xd6 24. ♖xd6 ♖d3±

22... ♖g6N

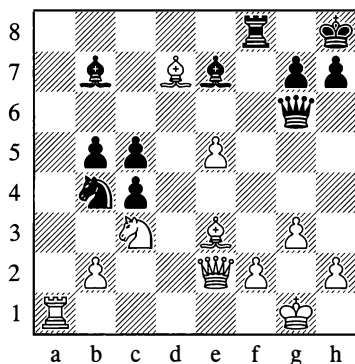
I now believe this to be a strong improvement.
22... ♖c5 23. e6 ♖g6 24. ♖d6± and White's
passed pawn decided the game quickly in
Danailov – Maksimovic, Cannes 1990.

23. ♖e3 ♖b4

In the case of 23... ♖c5 24. ♖xc5! ♖xc5
25. ♖e4 ♖e7 26. ♖d6 White has a clear plus,
thanks to his e-pawn.

24. ♖a1 c5!

A powerful idea indicated by my computer.
I had previously only considered 24... ♖a8
25. ♖xa8† ♖xa8 26. e6 ♖d3 27. ♖d1! with
an edge for White, as his queen is aiming
to penetrate via the a-file into Black's camp.
27... ♖f5 28. ♖a1 ♖f8 29. ♖a6 b4 30. ♖a4 c5
31. ♖c6 ♖xc6 32. ♖xc6 White's chances are
clearly preferable.

**25. ♖xb5 ♖c6!**

Due to his problems along the h1-a8
diagonal, White has to settle for a draw:

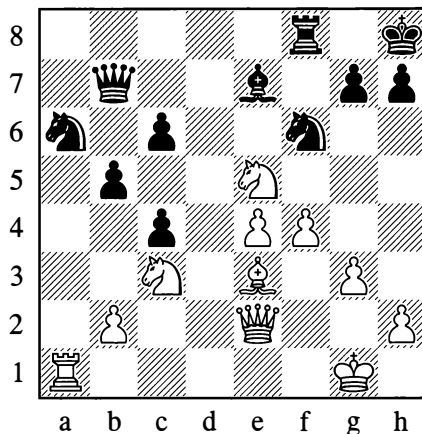
26. ♖d5 ♖e4 27. ♖c3 ♖g6=

19... ♖c8! 20. ♖xc8 ♖xc8

This was my original solution for Black, but
this time I decided to go deeper in my analysis.

21. f4 ♖a6 22. ♖a1! ♖b7

The threat of White penetrating with ♖a7
stops Black from moving his a6-knight.

**23. ♖f3!**

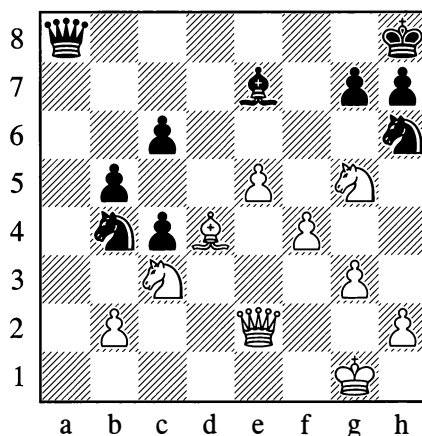
Pushing the e-pawn is always a key idea in
this type of position.

23... ♖a8 24. e5 ♖g4 25. ♖d4! ♖b4

25... c5 26. ♖f2 is good for White.

26. ♖xa8† ♖xa8 27. ♖g5 ♖h6

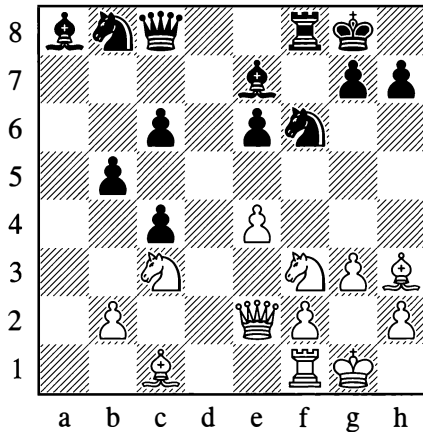
27... c5 28. ♖xg4 cxd4 29. ♖f7† ♖g8 30. ♖e6
is promising for White.



28.e6

White has a healthy initiative.

B42) 16...♖c8 17.♘f3



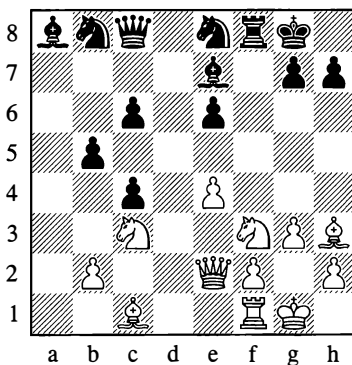
This looks to me to be the most logical continuation. First of all, White threatening to increase the pressure against the e6-pawn with ♘g5. Secondly, the idea of pushing e4-e5 followed by ♘e4 appears in some lines and makes a pleasant impression.

According to theory White has an important alternative in 17.♞d1 but, for the reasons mentioned above, I prefer the text.

17...♘a6

Played with the idea of defending the pawn with ...♘c7.

After 17...♘e8 I would like to suggest a new move:



18.♙g5N (18.♘g5 looks attractive, but after 18...♘c7 19.♙f4 ♘ba6 White had nothing special in Molina – Santiago, Laranjeiras 2012) 18...♞xf3 (18...♙xg5 19.♘xg5 ♘c7 20.♞g4 ♞e8 21.e5! h6 22.♘ge4 is clearly dangerous for Black) 19.♙xe7 ♞f7 20.♙a3! Grabbing Black's dark-squared bishop is definitely an achievement for White. 20...♘a6 21.♞d1 ♘ec7 22.♙d6 White's positional advantage is obvious.

18.♘g5

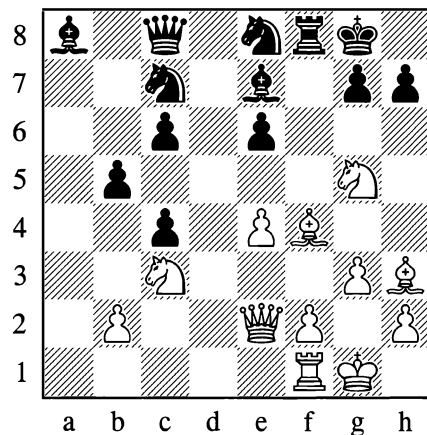
It's too early for 18.e5?!, which only helps Black to activate his pieces: 18...♘d5 19.♘e4 c5

18...♘c7

Clearly worse is 18...♘c5? 19.♙e3! ♘h8 20.♙xc5 ♙xc5 21.e5 and White had a winning attack in Haba – Meier, Pardubice 1999.

19.♙f4 ♘fe8

Black also cannot solve his problems with: 19...h6 20.♙xc7 hxg5 21.e5 ♘d5 (21...g4 allows White to develop a powerful attack with 22.exf6 ♞xf6 23.♙xg4 ♞xc7 24.♙xe6† ♘f8 25.♞e1!) 22.♙d6 ♘xc3 23.bxc3 ♞d7 24.♞g4!± With a clear advantage to White, Jardorf – Schroll, corr. 1993.

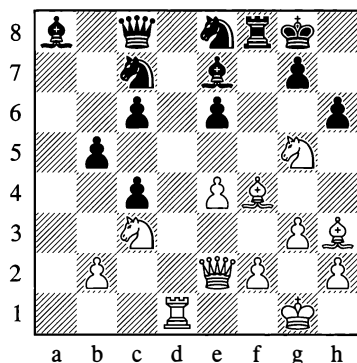
**20.♞d1!?**

My proposal from *GM 1* has now been tested a few times.

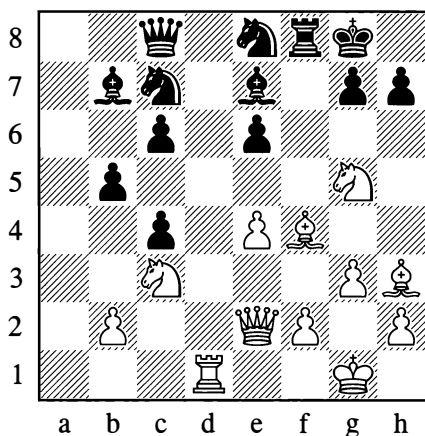
20. ♖g4 ♘f6!? 21. ♜xe6† ♘xe6 22. ♙xe6† was V. Zilberstein – I. Novikov, Blagoveschenk 1988, and now of course Black should have continued 22... ♜xe6 23. ♘xe6 ♝c8. Despite White's extra pawn I am not sure about the assessment of this position. Without queens on the board, Black's pawn mass on the queenside can quickly become a powerful force.

20... ♙b7

With 20...h6 Black is weakening the g6-square, which could become significant at a later stage. One game continued:



21. ♘f3 ♖h7 (21... ♙c5 22. ♘e5 ♘f6 23. ♘g6 ♝e8 24. e5 ♘fd5 25. ♘e4± with a dangerous initiative was the line from *GM 1*) 22. ♘e5 ♙d6?! 23. ♜h5 ♙xe5 24. ♜xe5 White had a clear advantage in Geisler – Galanov, email 2009.



21. ♜e3N

Once again White plays a quiet move. The queen takes control of the g1-a7 diagonal and prepares the move ♙e5, which is useful in some cases.

After 21. ♜g4 I believe that 21... ♘f6N is critical (21... ♙xc5 22. ♜xc5 h6 23. ♜c5 doesn't required much comment, Critter – Rybka, Internet 2012). 22. ♜h4 h6 23. ♙xc7 hxg5 24. ♜xc5 ♘d5 (24... ♜xc7 loses on the spot to 25. ♙xe6† ♝f7 26. e5) 25. exd5 ♙xc5 26. ♙xe6† ♝f7 27. ♙xc8 ♙xc8 Despite White's extra pawn, I feel that Black has decent chances to hold thanks to his bishop pair.

21...h6

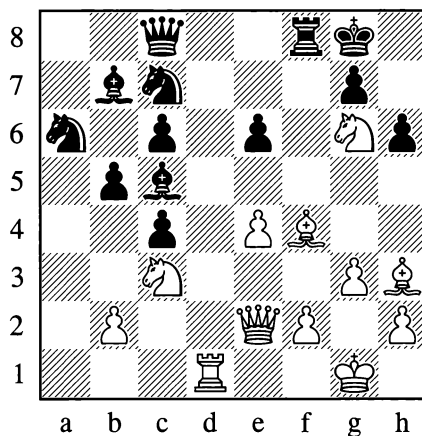
Black has virtually no useful options, so perhaps he has to play this weakening pawn move.

22. ♘f3 ♘a6

Black cannot solve his problems with 22...g5 23. ♙e5 ♘a6 (23...c5 runs into 24. ♘d5!±) 24. ♘d4 ♘c5 25. f4 ♘g7 26. f5 ♜e8 27. ♙xc7 ♜xc7 28. e5! with a winning attack.

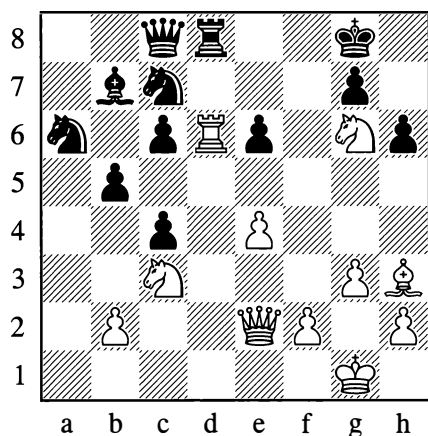
23. ♘e5 ♘ec7 24. ♘g6 ♙c5 25. ♜e2

This is even stronger than 25. ♜d2 as suggested in *GM 1*.



25...♖d8

If 25...♖f6 26.♘e5 ♕f8 27.♗h5, then White's initiative on the kingside should easily decide the game.

26.♘d6! ♕xd6 27.♖xd6

Having successfully traded dark-squared bishops, White's initiative looks extremely powerful.

Conclusion

The 5...a6 and 6...b5 variation seems to me to be slightly risky for Black, as White obtains rich play for the sacrificed pawn. I have always had the opinion that it would be too easy if Black could solve his opening problems in such a direct way. It has been especially pleasing to see many of my ideas and novelties from *GM 1* successfully tested in this line. I have also added some other improvements, and can say with confidence that White is in great shape here.